V-Dem VARIETIES OF DEMOCRACY | GLOBAL STANDARDS LOCAL KNOWLEDGE

PUBLIC LAUNCH
ALL WELCOME

Launching V-Dem in Australia and New Zealand

Comparative democracy research for our region and the world: how democracies change, how they are measured, and what we can learn by comparing them.

WHEN
Wednesday 9 December 2026
4:00 to 5:30 pm, followed by a reception

WHERE
Old Arts Hall
Old Arts Building, University of Melbourne

WHAT V-DEM DOES

600+
indicators of democracy, updated every year

4,200+
country experts rate the state of democracy

1789
to today, for all countries of the world

5
principles: electoral, liberal, participatory, deliberative, egalitarian

Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) goes beyond asking whether a country holds elections. Its data measure many dimensions of democracy and autocracy, so that countries can be compared with the same yardstick over more than two centuries. The V-Dem Institute at the University of Gothenburg leads the project, and the annual Democracy Report shows where democracy is advancing and where it is under pressure.

WHY IT MATTERS HERE

V-Dem works through nine regional centres, from the Balkans and the Caucasus to Latin America and Southern Africa. This launch brings Australia and New Zealand into the network. Our region combines long-established democracies, very different political systems among our neighbours in the Asia-Pacific, and close ties with Europe, an ideal setting for comparative research.

A JOINT CENTRE
The V-Dem Regional Centre for Australia and New Zealand is run jointly by the Australian National University and the University of Melbourne.

WHAT IT OPENS UP

1. Compare Australia and New Zealand with democracies and autocracies worldwide, using the same measures
2. A regional network of country experts and researchers
3. Data training, workshops and visiting scholars for students and early-career researchers
4. Joint research and funding, including EU and Australia projects on AI and democratic resilience
5. Evidence for policymakers, journalists and civil society

THE PANEL



Steven Wilson
Director, V-Dem Institute, University of Gothenburg

EXPERTISE
Comparative democratization, how the internet and social media shape authoritarian rule, cyber-security

REGIONAL FOCUS
The post-Soviet world



Carl-Henrik Knutsen
Professor of Political Science, University of Oslo, co-Principal Investigator of V-Dem

EXPERTISE
Democracy and autocracy, regime change, political and economic development

REGIONAL FOCUS
Global and historical comparison



Andrea Carson
Professor of Political Communication, University of Melbourne

EXPERTISE
Media and democracy, investigative journalism, misinformation and fact-checking, politics and gender

REGIONAL FOCUS
Australia



Bec Strating
Professor of International Relations and Director, Centre for Global Security, La Trobe University

EXPERTISE
International relations, Australian foreign and defence policy, maritime security

REGIONAL FOCUS
Indo-Pacific, Southeast Asia and Timor-Leste



CHAIR
Constanza Sanhueza Petrarca
Senior Lecturer, Australian National University
Director, V-Dem Regional Centre Australia and New Zealand



CHAIR
Seraphine Maerz
Senior Lecturer, University of Melbourne
Director, V-Dem Regional Centre Australia and New Zealand

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